

UNLOCKING YOUR CHILD'S INNER WRITER: TIPS FOR SUCCESS

Every parent has seen it: the sigh, the sluggish pencil grip, and the blank page that feels like an insurmountable hurdle. You beg, fail.. maybe even raise your voice - and they write even slower... Twenty minutes later, there's just one sentence on a blank paper. Writing can often feel like a monumental task, especially for reluctant young writers. But what if we told you there's a way to transform your child's dread into confidence and creativity?

As parents and educators, we have the unique opportunity to turn writing from a daunting chore into an exciting adventure. Here are research-backed tips to help your child unlock their inner writer.

THE REAL CHALLENGE: **Starting the Journey**

"The problem with writing is not poor spelling, punctuation, grammar and handwriting. The problem with writing is no writing."

Many students falter in English because they feel unmotivated or overwhelmed. Writing is still a cornerstone of academic success. Yet, for many students, the blank page represents a mountain they feel they'll never climb.

Making Writing Relatable

Connect writing to your child's interests and experiences using real-world approaches. Is your child passionate about video games, a certain movie, hobby or a recent family trip? **Encourage them to write about it!** Personal connections fuel motivation and creativity. Let them choose the format that suits them best - a poem, a short story, or even a comic strip. By giving your child choice over their writing, you empower them to take ownership of their writing journey, making the process more enjoyable and meaningful.

One of the best ways to help reluctant writers is to encourage them to read, listen, and discuss their ideas before they put pen to paper. At home, spark discussions and ask open questions allowing them to articulate their thoughts and ideas. Reading and discussing ideas for writing not only enhances their understanding, it also provides writers with the target language to express and clarify their thoughts, and activates their ideas to make the writing task more accessible when they begin.

Multimodal communication such as movies, clips, images and audio can motivate disengaged students, inspiring them to read and write. For example, show your child an image they can relate to or an engaging graphic novel like *The Boat* by Matt Huynh which combine visuals, audio, animation and storytelling, as a stimulus to inspire their writing and foster a positive attitude towards writing.



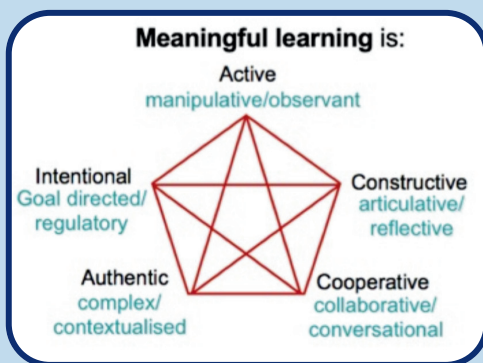
Embrace Technology

Contrary to what a majority of parents believe, technology isn't the enemy—it's a powerful ally. Today's students thrive in digital spaces, so why not meet them there? Writing doesn't have to be limited to essays.

A child who dreads pen-and-paper tasks might love creating a Spotify podcast or crafting a Tiktok for the fun of it or to share their unique perspective with the world.

Integrating technology to our writing tasks can make learning more meaningful by providing students with opportunities to investigate, experiment, document, design, visualise and communicate (*Jonassen et al., 2008*).

Tech tools also make revising less intimidating. Writing is a process, and apps or online platforms help students draft, edit, gather feedback from teachers and peers, and refine their work. This ease of revision encourages better clarity and fluency, helping your child see writing as an evolving skill rather than a one-shot effort.



Celebrate Progress, Not Perfection

Great writing takes time—just ask J.K. Rowling, who spent 5 YEARS revising Harry Potter (even experienced writers take years to refine their story!). Help your child understand that writing isn't about getting it perfect on the first try. Encourage them to experiment, reflect, and revise.

Revision is vital, helping students organise ideas, strengthen arguments, and refine their voice yet many students skip revision due to anxiety, laziness, ignorance, time constraints, "attitude" or a lack of understanding of its significance.

Research by Williams & Beam (2019) shows students can develop as writers if they understand and regularly practice going through the writing process, developing their writing skills and strategies.



A Real-Life Success Story

Take **Katherine Phung**, for example. Once a hesitant Year 4 writer, she blossomed through consistent encouragement and tailored strategies. I remember the days when I would need to dictate sentence starters, and sometimes entire sentences, to help inspire her. With the unwavering trust of her cooperative parents and the consistent application of these strategies, Katherine's writing abilities flourished.

Katherine overcame her aversion to writing and excelled, eventually achieving **2nd place in the Reading to Write preliminary exam**, and 1st place in her final exam essay for Module B Close Study of Literature at **Canley Vale High School**. Her journey shows how the right approach can transform even the most reluctant writer into a top performer.

TEN Real-Life Writing TRANSFORMATIONS I've Witnessed:

	Before	After	Period of Transformation with Mrs Jenny
Cindy Lam Current Y12 at St Johns Park HS	B average in primary school	2nd in Preliminary Year Overall	5 years (joined DA in Year 6)
Michelle Nguyen Current Y12 at Sefton HS	Started Year 11 in Standard English	Moved up to Advanced during Preliminary Year <i>(1st time in Sefton History)</i> + 1st ranking in Reading to Write Year 11 Assessment 1 + A range in Assessment 2 Mod A	1 year
Rachael Liu Current Y12 at Fairvale HS	B/C student in Year 9	2nd in Year 11 Preliminary Exam	2 years (joined DA in Year 8)
Charlene Vu Current Y12 at Fairvale HS	45th rank B average	Top 10 in Year 11 Preliminary Exam	6 months
Tammi Chiem Current Y12 Hurlstone HS	B average	A average	6 months
Felix Pittaglio Current Y10 at St Patrick's Marist College	B average	A average	6 months
Kathleen Giang Freeman HS	B average in Year 8	Top mark in HSC English at Freeman HS (Band 6)	4 years (joined DA in year 5)
Brendan Nguyen Prairiewood HS	C average in Year 9	Top 2 ranking in HSC year (98% mark for preliminary exam)	3 years (joined DA in year 7)
Jessica Nguyen Prairiewood HS	A average	Averaging 100% & topping English from Year 9 onwards (99+ ATAR, 2nd in HSC year)	2 years
Leyna Ngo Sefton HS	"Maths person, not English person" A average	Top 3 in English 99+ Atar	4 years (joined DA in Year 5)



Writing: A Lifelong Skill



By connecting writing to your child's world, using technology as a tool, and celebrating their growth, you can turn writing from a dreaded task into a powerful form of self-expression. The key is starting small, encouraging effort, and showing them that their words matter.

If you're a parent seeking to nurture your child's writing potential, or a student eager to unlock your own, don't hesitate to contact Miss Lai, Miss Linda, or myself—we'll help you find the perfect tutor to guide you on your journey today!